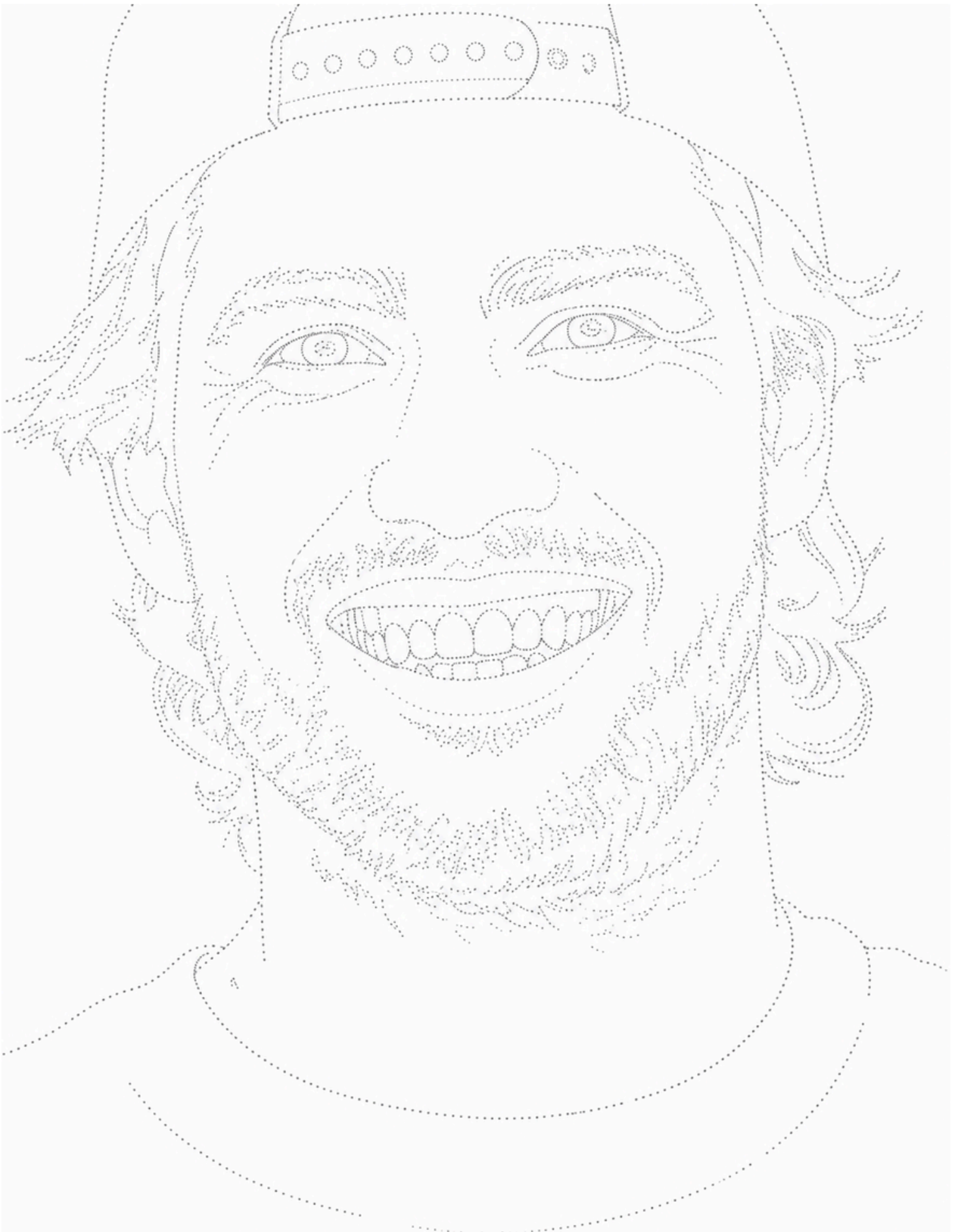


Line art — print at A4, 100% scale. Personal practice use.



PortraitGuide017



Difficulty Advanced Est. time 8–12 hours

Subject A middle-aged with loose curly dark brown hair, warm olive-golden medium-deep skin tone, visible short stubble or light beard on the chin and lower jaw, wearing a white cap and white shirt, with a calm, neutral expression.

Pencils Prismacolor Premier

• MATERIALS

Two ways to work this guide. Every pencil number below is a Prismacolor Premier number — the 24 set covers the roles, the 150 set covers the exact numbers. Each step also names what its key pencil is *doing*, so a substitution never breaks the sequence.

Starting out

Prismacolor Premier Colored Pencils — Set of 24, Portrait Colors — the skin colors this guide uses (warm mid-light, cool dark, warm earth, saturated accent) all exist in the 24. Where a step or garment names a number you don't have, swatch with whatever you like or close.

Strathmore 300 Bristol, vellum surface, 9×12 — vellum tooth holds the layer counts below; smooth plate clogs in half the layers.

If you want the exact set-up

Prismacolor Premier, 150 set — every pencil number in this guide comes from this set, so nothing needs substituting.

Legion Stonehenge drawing paper — a softer, more forgiving tooth that takes more layers before it fills, and burnishes to a smoother finish.

Either way: kneaded eraser · electric eraser · a colorless blender. **No solvent** — every blend in this guide is dry.

• COLOR PALETTE



Nectar

PC1092

Base light warm red-orange; primary mid-light skin tone across lit planes (forehead, cheekbones, nose bridge); optical mixing anchor.



Peach

PC939

Warm light red-orange; brightens lit planes, especially nose tip and cheekbone peaks where subsurface light glows; supports luminosity.



Beige Sienna

PC1080

Light warm red-orange with golden depth; transitions lit zones to midtones; warm glow on face and neck without harsh line.



Henna

PC1031

Mid warm red-orange; second optical mixing layer over Nectar for richer tone; shadows on upper lip; stubble structure.



Light Umber

PC941

Mid warm red-orange; core shadow definition on cheekbone; shadow planes and gradation; jaw and neck shadow; stubble midtone.



Espresso

PC1099

Mid-dark warm brown; shadow plane depth on cheeks and temples; dark hair mass base; stubble directional structure.



Dark Umber

PC947

Very dark warm brown; deepest shadows and dark hair foundation; stubble density on central chin.



90% Warm Grey

PC1058

Neutral grey with warm undertone; value map foundation midtone; garment folds and shadows; subtle background.



Sky Blue Light

PC1086

Very light teal-green; cool bounce light from white cap onto lower jaw and neck; sclera base; atmospheric background.



Light Aqua

PC992

Very light teal-green; pale atmospheric glaze for background unification; aerial perspective.



90% French Grey

PC1076

Near-black neutral; value map deepest shadow anchor; pupils and upper lash line; final dark re-darkening after burnish.



20% Cool Grey

PC1060

Near-white cool neutral; garment shadow form; tooth gaps (subtle); foundation highlight value.



Cream

PC914

Warm pale highlight; value map light plane anchor; burnishing and surface smoothing; edge softening; sheen band on hair.



Sepia

PC948

Warm dark brown; shadow foundation and core-shadow edges; warm reflected light in shadows; mouth shape and lip creases; background depth.



Violet Blue

PC933

Cool violet; chromatic shadow complement to warm skin (optically enhances luminosity); iris perimeter depth; upper lip cool shadow.



White

PC938

Pure white; final peak highlights on forehead, nose bridge, cheekbone, lower lip; burnishing and surface smoothing; garment rim light.



Black

PC935

Pure black; final re-darkening of pupils and lash line after burnish-induced lightening; deepest definition lines.

LIGHT & SHADOW ANALYSIS

Light source direction Soft, diffuse key light from slightly left-front; appears to be broad, non-harsh window or studio key with high-angle ambient fill.

HIGHLIGHT

Forehead apex, bridge and tip of nose, highest points of cheekbones, light catchings on the loose curls; warm, glowing quality indicating subsurface light and translucency.

LIGHT AREA

Lit side of face (right side of subject), lit planes of nose, upper cheeks, front of white cap, shirt front, some curl highlights.

MIDTONE

General face plane transitioning between lit and shadow; neck and jaw receiving mixed key and ambient light; hair mid-mass areas between dark clumps.

SHADOW

Under cheekbones (core shadow with crisp terminator), eye sockets, temple shade, away-side jaw, under-chin shadow, hair masses in shadow; warm, oxidized quality (no cool grey).

CAST SHADOW

Soft shadow under jaw onto neck; cast from upper features onto lower face minimal due to soft light.

Edge quality notes

Soft, diffuse lighting produces gradual terminators on rounded forms (cheeks, nose); no harsh shadow lines; all edges remain integrated rather than cut. The lash line is the single sharpest edge in the study. Cap brim casts a subtle shadow on upper forehead and eye area.

• STEP-BY-STEP INSTRUCTIONS

OI Step 1: Value Map Foundation

Entire face, establishing tonal range

Light-pressure overlapping marks, no blending yet; tonal range from white paper (brightest) through all midtones to near-black (darkest).

Light pressure

- Value carries form; colored pencil cannot lift pigment, so establish the full tonal range early at light pressure to preserve paper tooth for all layers to come.
- Using PC914 Cream at very light pressure, block in the lit planes (forehead, nose bridge, cheekbones, lit side of face) with soft, overlapping marks.
- Using PC1058 90% Warm Grey at light pressure, establish midtone zones across the face and jaw.
- Using PC948 Sepia at light pressure, place the core shadows (under cheekbones, eye sockets, neck underplane, sides of face).
- Using PC1076 90% French Grey at very light pressure only, hint at the deepest shadow zones (pupils, inner eye corners, darkest cast shadows) — do not fill these areas, only suggest them.

COLORS



PC914 Cream



PC1058 90% Warm Grey



PC948 Sepia



PC1076 90% French Grey

↔ PC914 Cream provides the light tone — any pale yellow or off-white works (Cream, White, Light Peach); PC1058 90% Warm Grey blocks the midtones — any neutral grey (90% Warm Grey, 90% French Grey); PC948 Sepia anchors the warm shadows — any dark warm tone (Dark Umber, Sepia, Burnt Ochre) substitutes; PC1076 90% French Grey is the deepest darks — any near-black works.

STOP WHEN

The pencil is still sliding easily across the paper · you can see all the value zones but the paper texture is still clearly visible

✦ *Do NOT blend yet. Overlapping light marks at the same light pressure will optically mix without killing the paper tooth. This is the foundation; it must stay airy. Resist the urge to darken — you cannot reach dark only by layering from here forward.*

O2 Step 2: Mid-Tone and Undertone Skin Layers

Entire face, all lit and midtone areas

Circular strokes at light pressure; thin, distinct layers without blending; each layer remains visible to the next for optical luminosity.

Light pressure

- Skin is translucent and scatters light, so warm red-orange and yellow pigments beneath the surface make skin glow rather than read as painted — build in thin, chromatic layers instead of one 'skin color' pencil.
- First pass: Using PC1092 Nectar at light pressure, apply gentle circular strokes across all lit areas (forehead, nose bridge, cheekbones, lit side of face) without blending.
- Once that layer is set, apply PC1031 Henna over the same areas at light pressure — the two hues optically mix to a richer, more luminous tone without burnishing.
- Second pass: Using PC939 Peach at light pressure, warm the lit planes further, especially the nose tip and cheekbone peaks where subsurface light glows brightest.
- Apply PC1080 Beige Sienna across midtones and the transition zone between lit and shadow for golden, alive skin tone; use circular strokes and stay at light pressure.

COLORS ● PC1092 Nectar

● PC1031 Henna

● PC939 Peach

● PC1080 Beige Sienna

↔ PC1092 Nectar is the light warm base — substitute any light red-orange or peachy tone (Peach, Nectar, Light Peach); PC1031 Henna adds warmth depth — substitute any mid warm tone (Light Umber, Henna, Cadmium Orange Hue); PC939 Peach brightens lit zones — use any light warm saturated tone (Peach, Light Peach, Beige Sienna); PC1080 Beige Sienna warms midtones — any mid warm gold-orange tone works.

STOP WHEN

The face shows distinct warm tones layered in sequence · the pencil is still sliding, not dragging, and individual strokes are still visible

✦ *Never burnish yet. Each layer must remain visible to the next one for optical mixing to work. Translucency is everything; opacity muddies. The goal is luminous skin, not opaque coverage.*

03 Step 3: Shadow Planes and Depth — The Cheekbone Terminator

Cheeks, temples, jaw sides; shadow-side plane and core-shadow edges

Directional strokes following form contours; core shadow edge crisp, shadow interior gradated; warm pigments only (no cool grey or ashy tones).

Medium-Light to Medium pressure

- The core shadow (where light meets shadow on a curved form like the cheekbone) has a sharp edge because the form turns quickly; keep this edge crisp and warm, never a soft grey blur, so the face reads as round and solid.
- Using PC941 Light Umber at medium-light pressure, place a defined line where the cheekbone catches its core shadow — this is your reference point for form and the sharpest edge in the shadow area.
- Using PC1099 Espresso at medium pressure, build the shadow planes (cheek underplane, temple shadow, jaw shadow) with directional strokes following the form's contour.
- Layer PC948 Sepia into the deepest shadow zones (neck underplane, inner eye corners, shadow side of the cheek) to keep shadows warm and oxidized, never cool grey.
- Maintain a clear gradation from the lit plane through the core shadow to the reflected-light zone — the eye reads depth from this separation, not from darkness alone.

COLORS

● PC941 Light Umber

● PC1099 Espresso

● PC948 Sepia

↔ PC941 Light Umber is the core shadow definition — substitute any mid warm tone (Henna, Light Umber, Burnt Ochre); PC1099 Espresso deepens the shadow mass — any dark warm brown works (Dark Umber, Espresso, Sepia); PC948 Sepia enriches the darkest shadows — substitute any dark warm tone (Sepia, Dark Umber, Burnt Ochre).

STOP WHEN

A crisp terminator edge is visible where light meets core shadow · shadow areas feel warm (orange/brown), not cool or ashy

✦ A common mistake: making the shadow side too dark. In soft light like this, the away-side plane is MID-value and warm. Overdarking it flattens the head. Hold back. The core shadow edge is sharp; the shadow interior is gradated and warm.

04 Step 4: Skin Burnishing and Surface Refinement

Entire face, forehead to jaw

Circular burnishing strokes at medium pressure; smooth pigment across each zone until no white paper specks or grain is visible.

Medium pressure

- Paper tooth is finite — once crushed with heavy pressure, no more pigment bonds to it. Burnishing smooths the grain while the tooth is still visible, creating even, glowing skin that reads as unified rather than blotchy or grainy.
- Using PC914 Cream at medium pressure with circular motions, burnish across the entire face — start with the light areas (forehead, nose, cheekbones) and work toward midtones.
- Keep the darkest shadows (core shadows, inner eye corners) unburned for now — preserve a little tooth there for the final darks to grab.
- Work in small sections (one cheek at a time) with circular, not linear, strokes — pressing from the center outward slightly to even the pigment.
- Gently wipe any wax bloom (hazy white coating) with a soft, dry cloth or use a light workable fixative to clear it; do not scrub.

COLORS ● PC914 Cream

↔ PC914 Cream is the warm burnishing tone — substitute any pale cream or off-white (Cream, White, Light Peach); PC938 White is an alternative very-light burnish.

STOP WHEN

The skin surface is smooth and even, with no visible grain or specks · the pencil is gliding smoothly and the color is uniform across each zone

✦ *Burnishing is cumulative and non-reversible — each pass melts the layers together. Do this once per skin zone, then stop. If you burnish too early, the layers below are locked in and you cannot add shadow depth easily later. After burnishing, you must re-darken the shadows.*

05 Step 5: Eyes — Pupils, Iris, and Lash Definition

Both eyes and immediate surrounds; focus on structure and dimension

Pupils opaque and solid; iris radial layering; upper lash crisp and dark; lower lash soft and light; one highlight point only.

Varies: Light for iris and sclera, Firm for upper lash, Light for lower lash, Heavy for highlight pressure

- The eye is a sphere (sclera), shadowed underneath, with a darker torus (iris) at the front and an opaque, light-blocking sphere (pupil) at the center — render the pupil dark and opaque to push it back spatially, and keep the sclera cool and not pure white so it reads as dimensional.
- Using PC1076 90% French Grey, block in the pupil as a solid dot — this is the darkest, most opaque mark in the eye area.
- With PC1086 Sky Blue Light at very light pressure, lay a glaze across the sclera (the white of the eye) — it is never pure white, but a cool, soft blue-grey.
- Using radial strokes from the pupil outward, apply PC1031 Henna for the iris warm-red tones, then layer PC933 Violet Blue around the iris perimeter for depth and reflection.
- Using PC1076 90% French Grey at firm pressure, draw a crisp, dark upper lash line — this is the hardest edge in the eye area and a focal point.
- Using PC948 Sepia at light pressure, place the lower lid shadow (soft, diffuse, lighter than the upper lid) — never mirror the upper lid; asymmetry creates life.
- Finally, with PC938 White on a sharp pencil, add ONE bright specular highlight on the pupil (positioned where light actually catches it from the key light direction) — this single point gives the eye life and dimension.

COLORS

● PC1076 90% French Grey

● PC1086 Sky Blue Light

● PC1031 Henna

● PC933 Violet Blue

● PC948 Sepia

● PC938 White

↔ PC1076 90% French Grey is the pupil and upper lash — substitute any near-black (Black, 90% French Grey, Indigo Blue); PC1086 Sky Blue Light is the sclera cool tone — any very light cool tone works (Light Aqua, Sky Blue Light); PC1031 Henna warms the iris — any warm red-orange substitutes (Peach, Nectar, Henna); PC933 Violet Blue cools the iris — any cool violet/blue works (Periwinkle, Violet Blue, Deco Peach); PC948 Sepia is the lower lid — any soft warm dark works (Sepia, Burnt Ochre, Dark Umber); PC938 White is the highlight — must be white or very light cream.

STOP WHEN

The pupil is dark and opaque · the iris shows radial structure with warm and cool tones · the upper and lower lids are clearly asymmetrical, with the upper dark and crisp, the lower soft

✦ *Upper lash line sharp and dark; lower lash line soft and lighter. This asymmetry is what makes eyes look alive, not like two identical half-moons. The highlight is the final*

06 Step 6: Lips and Teeth — Individual Mouth Rendering

Mouth area: lips, teeth, mouth line

Asymmetrical upper/lower rendering; subtle tooth shadow only; delicate creases at the end; soft lip-line integration.

Very Light to Light; Firm only for crease definition lines pressure

- The lower lip is convex and catches light, so it is warmer, lighter and more saturated than the upper lip, which is shadowed by the upper teeth — render this asymmetry clearly so the mouth feels dimensional rather than flat and outlined.
- Using PC948 Sepia at very light pressure, sketch the mouth shape and any visible tooth edges — this establishes the form structure without committing to heavy marks.
- Upper lip: Using PC1031 Henna with a glaze of PC933 Violet Blue at light pressure, keep the upper lip darker and cooler than the lower — it is in shadow and recedes spatially.
- Lower lip: Apply PC939 Peach at light-medium pressure for warmth and saturation — the lower lip glows warmer and catches more light than the upper.
- Teeth: Using PC1060 20% Cool Grey very lightly, shadow only the gaps between teeth and any internal cracks; leave most of the tooth surface white to imply strong light reflection. Do not outline teeth or make them stark.
- Lip line: Using a sharp pencil and PC948 Sepia at very light pressure, draw fine horizontal creases across the lips (4–6 creases) — these are the last detail added, and they must be delicate, not bold.
- Blend the lip-to-skin boundary with light circular strokes using PC1092 — the lip line is soft and integrated, never a hard outline.

COLORS ● PC948 Sepia ● PC1031 Henna ● PC933 Violet Blue ● PC939 Peach
● PC1060 20% Cool Grey ● PC1092 Nectar

↔ PC1031 Henna shadows the upper lip — any mid warm tone works (Henna, Light Umber, Burnt Ochre); PC933 Violet Blue cools the upper lip — any cool tone (Violet Blue, Periwinkle, Deco Peach); PC939 Peach warms the lower lip — any light warm saturated tone (Peach, Light Peach, Nectar); PC948 Sepia is for creases and form — any sharp dark warm pencil; PC1060 20% Cool Grey subtly shadows teeth — any very light cool tone or light grey; PC1092 Nectar softens the lip line — any warm tone matching the surrounding skin.

STOP WHEN

The upper and lower lips are clearly different in value and temperature · the tooth gaps are subtle, not stark or outlined · lip creases are fine lines, not heavy marks · the lip line blends softly into the surrounding skin

✦ *Lips are often overworked. A strong, saturated lower lip and a cooler, subtle upper lip are often more convincing than symmetrically rendered lips. Asymmetry is life. Teeth are nearly white; shadow only the gaps. An outlined tooth is a dead give-away of amateur rendering.*

07 Step 7: Facial Hair — Stubble Structure and Gradation

Chin, jaw, lower face and neck; short stubble and beard density

Directional short strokes following growth; graduated density heaviest on chin, lightest on edges; gaps between marks to show skin texture; soft fade at boundaries.

Light to Medium-Light pressure

- Facial hair is a structure of individual marks following the growth direction, not a wash of color — render stubble as graduated density with directional strokes so it reads as hair texture on skin, not a shadow tint.
- Using PC1099 Espresso at light pressure, sketch the stubble direction (slightly downward on the chin, across the jaw and neck) with short directional strokes that follow the growth pattern.
- Build density gradually: place more strokes on the chin center (where stubble is densest and darkest), fewer on the sides and neck (where it thins and fades to clean skin).
- Second pass: Using PC947 Dark Umber at light-medium pressure, deepen the densest stubble areas (central chin, lower jaw line) without making a solid wash.
- Third pass: Using PC941 Light Umber, add the midtone stubble marks between the dark ones and on the face/neck boundary where stubble is finer and lighter.
- Leave small gaps between stubble marks (do not make a solid fill) — individual hair marks with skin showing through read as texture, not shadow.
- Blend the soft edges at the boundary where stubble fades to clean skin with light circular strokes using PC1092 — transition smoothly, never an abrupt line.

COLORS  PC1099 Espresso  PC947 Dark Umber  PC941 Light Umber

 PC1092 Nectar

↔ PC1099 Espresso builds the stubble structure — any dark warm tone (Espresso, Dark Umber, Sepia); PC947 Dark Umber deepens — substitute any dark warm tone; PC941 Light Umber is the midtone stubble — any mid warm tone (Light Umber, Henna, Burnt Ochre); PC1092 Nectar softens edges — any warm skin tone matching surrounding face.

STOP WHEN

Individual stubble marks are visible, with gaps between them · the density is heaviest on the chin, lightest on the sides and neck · the pencil is still sliding, not dragging

✦ *The most common mistake: laying stubble as a flat, blended wash. It flattens into a shadow and loses all dimension. Stubble is texture — directional marks with visible gaps. Each mark is a hair, not a shadow. If you've blended too much, it's too late; add more directional marks over the blend.*

08 Step 8: Hair — Curly Structure, Volume, and Sheen

All visible hair on the head, including curls on sides and back

Curved strokes following curl direction; value layering (dark, mid, light) with gaps between; warm sheen band on the light-struck areas; few bright highlights only.

Light to Medium; Very Light for highlights pressure

- Dark hair reads from value variation and a sheen band, not from flatness — build it from dark brown, navy and deep violet layered with lighter midtones and a warm highlight band, so it reads as dimensional hair with form and light rather than a silhouette.
- First pass: Using PC947 Dark Umber, follow the curly hair growth direction with curved strokes — the curves should follow the direction each curl is moving, not straight down the head.
- Second pass: Using PC1099 Espresso, deepen the darkest hair mass (crown area, behind ears, any areas in shadow) with curved strokes that follow the curl direction.
- Third pass: Using PC941 Light Umber, place the midtone hair values between the dark clumps — this adds dimension and shows the light hitting the hair's surface between curls.
- Highlight pass: Using PC1092 Nectar or PC1080 Beige Sienna very lightly, place the sheen band (the warm highlight area where light catches the curved top of the curls) — follow the curve of the head and the direction of the curl mass.
- Final texture: Using PC914 Cream at very light pressure, add a few bright individual highlights on the brightest curl edges — these are rare and deliberate, not scattered everywhere.
- Reserve paper tooth for the lightest streaks early; burnish the sheen band only very lightly in a final pass to make it glow.

COLORS  PC947 Dark Umber  PC1099 Espresso  PC941 Light Umber

 PC1092 Nectar  PC1080 Beige Sienna  PC914 Cream

↔ PC947 Dark Umber is the darkest base — substitute any dark warm tone (Dark Umber, Black, Indigo Blue); PC1099 Espresso deepens the mass — any dark warm works (Espresso, Sepia, Black); PC941 Light Umber is the midtone — any mid tone (Light Umber, Henna, Burnt Ochre); PC1092 Nectar or PC1080 Beige Sienna are the warm sheen highlights — any light warm tone (Nectar, Peach, Beige Sienna); PC914 Cream adds the brightest streaks — use any very light tone (Cream, White, Light Peach).

STOP WHEN

The hair shows dark, midtone and light zones · the strokes follow the curl direction, not the head shape alone · a warm sheen band is visible on the brightest curves · individual light streaks are sparse and bright

✦ *Dark hair is never one flat value. The sheen band is what makes it read as three-dimensional — it's a highlight band, not individual strands. Follow the curve of the form, not a flat pattern. If hair looks like a solid mass, add more midtone variation between the darks to show form.*

09 Step 9: Neck and Garment — Transition and White Cap/Shirt

Neck, jaw-to-shoulder transition; white cap and white shirt front

Neck: thin skin-tone layers blended smoothly to face; garment: very light cool shadows and warm fold shadows, with cool bounce light glaze; rim light sparse.

Light to Medium-Light pressure

- The neck continues the form of the head and must feel connected; skin color on the neck is slightly cooler and less saturated than on the face because it receives less direct light and reflects more ambient light — the garment (white cap and shirt) bounces cool light downward onto the lower jaw and neck.
- Neck skin: Using PC1092 Nectar and PC1031 Henna at light pressure, apply skin tone layers to the neck with the same technique as the face, but at slightly lower saturation — the neck is warm but not as rosy as the cheeks.
- Self-shadow under jaw: Using PC941 Light Umber at light-medium pressure, place a soft self-shadow on the underplane of the jaw where it turns away from light — keep this warm, not harsh or grey.
- Blend the face-to-neck with circular strokes using PC1092 so no hard line forms — skin should flow from face to neck seamlessly.
- Garment — white cap and shirt: Using PC1060 20% Cool Grey at very light pressure, block in the white areas with subtle cool shadows — white reads through cool, subtle grey shadows in soft light, never with heavy dark shadows.
- Garment folds: Using PC1058 90% Warm Grey, add subtle form shadows in the folds (under the cap brim, shirt folds, where the shirt turns into shadow).
- Bounce light from garment: Using PC1086 Sky Blue Light at very light pressure, lay an almost invisible cool glaze on the lower jaw and neck where the white cap and shirt bounce light upward — this unifies the garment and skin and indicates the light source.
- Rim light: Using PC938 White very lightly, add a hint of rim light on the cap edge or shirt front where it catches the key light.

COLORS  PC1092 Nectar  PC1031 Henna  PC941 Light Umber

 PC1060 20% Cool Grey  PC1058 90% Warm Grey  PC1086 Sky Blue Light

 PC938 White

↔ PC1092 Nectar and PC1031 Henna are the neck skin tones — any light warm tone substitutes; PC941 Light Umber is the jaw self-shadow — any mid warm tone; PC1060 20% Cool Grey is the garment shadow — any very light cool tone (20% Cool Grey, 20% French Grey); PC1058 90% Warm Grey adds garment depth — any mid neutral grey; PC1086 Sky Blue Light is the bounce light — any very light cool tone (Sky Blue Light, Light Aqua); PC938 White is the rim light — only white works.

STOP WHEN

The neck feels connected to the face · the garment shows form through subtle shadow, not heavy or harsh · cool light from the garment is barely visible but present

✦ *The garment is white but has form. Avoid leaving it blank or stark — subtle cool shadows and the bounce light unify it with the face. The underside of the jaw should glow slightly cool from the white shirt — that's what sells the spatial relationship between face and garment.*

IO Step 10: Background and Atmospheric Color

Background areas and composition edges; atmospheric unification

Very light circular strokes; minimal saturation; soft, diffuse edges; almost imperceptible presence.

Very Light pressure

- Atmospheric color (very light cool tone) in the background unifies the portrait and pushes the background away through value and saturation contrast — the subject must be the most saturated and darkest element, so the background stays pale and soft.
- Using PC992 Light Aqua at very light pressure, lay a nearly invisible glaze across the background areas (around the head, shoulders and any edge areas) with circular strokes.
- Where the background is furthest from the subject (top and side edges), deepen slightly with PC1086 Sky Blue Light at light pressure — still very pale and soft, never competing with the face.
- Keep the background value very light (much lighter than the face) and saturation low — this ensures the subject remains the focus and the background recedes.
- Do not use hard edges between the subject and background — the transition should be soft and diffuse, with the background subtly integrated.

COLORS



PC992 Light Aqua



PC1086 Sky Blue Light

↔ PC992 Light Aqua is the pale atmospheric blue — substitute any very light cool tone (Light Aqua, Sky Blue Light, Powder Blue); PC1086 Sky Blue Light deepens the distant background — any light cool tone works (Sky Blue Light, Light Aqua).

STOP WHEN

The background is barely visible, almost a whisper · the subject stands out clearly from the background through value contrast alone

✦ *A background that is too obvious or too dark will kill the portrait. Less is more here. The background should be almost imperceptible — it's there to unify, not to compete. If you can see the background clearly, it's too strong; dial it back.*

II Step 11: Final Details, Edge Hierarchy, and Wax Bloom Correction

Entire portrait; edge refinement, bloom correction, and peak highlights

Soft-edge blending with pale tones; brief, firm re-darkening of deepest darks; sparse, bright white highlights at peak light points only.

Light for edge softening; Heavy for dark re-darkening; Heavy for highlights pressure

- Edge hierarchy (hard edges advance, soft edges recede) controls where the eye looks — the lash line is the focal point and must be the hardest, sharpest edge; all other edges soften outward (hair into background, jaw into shadow, garment into diffuse light) so the eye naturally travels to the lash line and stays there.
- Identify the focal point (the lash line) — this edge stays CRISP and hard. Do not soften it. Verify its darkness against the corrected value scale.
- Soften the hair edges into the background with light circular strokes using PC914 Cream or PC1092 — lose the hard hair-to-background line so hair floats rather than cuts.
- Soften the jaw into shadow on the away-side face — a gentle blend of the jaw line into the neck shadow so the face feels integrated.
- Soften the garment edges — the shoulder line, cap edge and shirt-to-neck should flow softly, not cut sharply.
- Check for wax bloom (a hazy white coating that appears after burnishing) — gently wipe it with a soft, dry cloth or apply a light workable fixative without scrubbing.
- Punch back the deepest darks after bloom removal: Using PC935 Black and PC1076 90% French Grey with brief, firm pressure, darken the pupils, lash line and any cast shadows that may have lightened during burnishing — this step is essential and often skipped.
- Add peak highlights: With PC938 White on a sharp pencil, place ONE bright highlight on each major light-catching point (forehead apex, nose bridge, nose tip, cheekbone peak, lower lip center, highest curl) — each highlight is small and deliberate, not scattered everywhere.

COLORS ● PC914 Cream ● PC1092 Nectar ● PC935 Black
● PC1076 90% French Grey ● PC938 White

↔ PC914 Cream softens edges — any pale tone (Cream, White, Light Peach); PC1092 Nectar for warm edge blending — any warm skin tone; PC935 Black punches the darkest darks — only black works here for true depth; PC1076 90% French Grey re-darkens also — any near-black; PC938 White adds peak highlights — only white or very light cream.

STOP WHEN

The lash line is crisp and sharp · all other edges are soft or lost · the darkest darks have been re-established and match the reference · highlights are bright, not dull, and placed on peaks only

✦ *Edge hierarchy is the last and most powerful tool for controlling focus. A portrait with a soft lash line and a hard garment edge looks unfinished or incorrect. Reverse the hierarchy and the eye travels where you planned. Burnishing can lighten values unexpectedly — always punch the darks back. Peak highlights must be rare and bright, not multiple dull spots. One small, bright highlight per area is the rule.*

• WHEN YOU FINISH IT

Leave a comment under the video with a photo of your drawing. I'll run it through the same three lines the AI runs on mine — the verdict, the one thing to fix, and what to target next.

Free. I read all of them, and the ones I answer go in the comments so everyone else can see the same correction.